Writing a formal letter and an email

Goal: To write a short formal letter and a formal email with the correct layout, opening and closing formulas, and a polite, clear register.

The idea in two lines: A formal letter or email follows a fixed structure: greeting, purpose, details, request, polite closing. The language is formal: no contractions, no slang, polite full sentences.

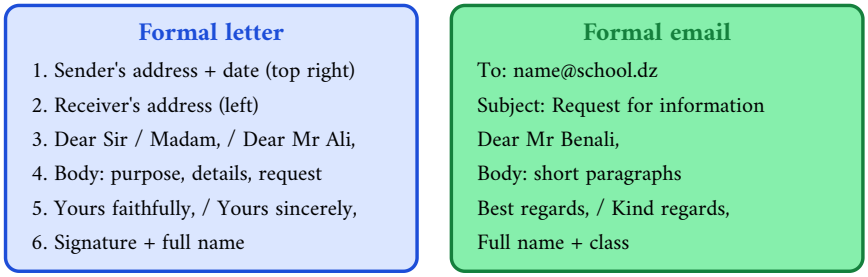


Figure 1: Layout of a formal letter (left) and a formal email (right).

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Layout of a letter:** your address and the date at the top right, the receiver's name and address on the left, then the greeting.
2. **Greeting:** "Dear Sir / Madam," when you do not know the name; "Dear Mr / Mrs / Ms + surname," when you do.
3. **Closing:** "Yours faithfully," after Dear Sir / Madam; "Yours sincerely," after a name. In an email: "Best regards," or "Kind regards,".
4. **Opening sentence** states the purpose: I am writing to apply for... / to ask for information about... / to complain about...
5. **Body paragraphs:** one idea per paragraph; details, then the request: I would be grateful if you could...
6. **Final sentence:** I look forward to hearing from you. / Thank you for your attention.

7. **Email specifics:** a clear **subject line**, no postal addresses, short paragraphs, same formal register.

🟢 Examples

1. Opening of a letter asking for information about a language course: **Answer:** "Dear Sir / Madam, I am writing to ask for information about the summer English course advertised on your website. Could you please tell me the dates and the fees?" **Explanation:** unknown receiver → Dear Sir / Madam; purpose in the first sentence; polite question.
2. Closing an email to a teacher you know by name: **Answer:** "I look forward to your reply. Kind regards, Yasmine Hadj, 1AS2." **Explanation:** final polite sentence, email closing, full name and class.
3. Make formal: "Hey, can u send me the papers asap?" **Answer:** "I would be grateful if you could send me the documents as soon as possible." **Explanation:** no abbreviations, no slang, polite request form.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Using contractions and informal words (I'm, can't, hi, thanks a lot) in a formal letter.
- Mixing closings: "Dear Sir, ... Yours sincerely" instead of "Yours faithfully".
- Forgetting the subject line in an email or the date in a letter.
- Writing one long paragraph with no clear purpose sentence.

🟡 Quick review

- Letter: addresses + date → greeting → purpose → details → request → closing → name.
- Dear Sir / Madam ↔ Yours faithfully; Dear Mr X ↔ Yours sincerely.
- Email: subject line, short paragraphs, Best / Kind regards.
- Formal = no contractions, no slang, polite forms (I would be grateful if...).
- End with: I look forward to hearing from you.

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